SESSION 07

Typography as Architectural Voice

Type is the last decision that still reads as a design decision.

Portfolio as Narrative · Typeface, Pairing, and Hierarchy

Why Today Matters

Type Speaks When You Are Not in the Room

- A reviewer reads your typography before they read a single word.
- **The typeface, the size hierarchy, and the spacing** have already said discipline or disorder.
- **Choosing type is a design decision,** and it should reinforce the position your project takes.
- Next you pick a pairing that fits your argument and test it on a spread.

WHAT THE PAGE SAYS FIRST

- **The typeface** the voice
- **The size hierarchy** the order
- **The spacing** the pace

From Module 12: Typography and Type Hierarchy.

CONCEPT

One Sentence, Three Voices

Same words, three typefaces. Only the typeface changed.

MODERNIST

The proposal introduces a modular timber structure that functions as a stable framework for diverse and shifting needs.

Helvetica

Reads as precise and quiet.

HUMANIST

The proposal introduces a modular timber structure that functions as a stable framework for diverse and shifting needs.

Avenir

Reads as approachable and warm.

SERIF

The proposal introduces a modular timber structure that functions as a stable framework for diverse and shifting needs.

Palatino

Reads as formal and considered.

Text: Flexible Framework statement (National Building Arts Center, St. Louis), the worked example in the Typeface Guide (WashU St. Louis, Spring 2021). Palatino stands in for the editorial serifs.

CONCEPT

Four Typeface Categories

The Typeface Guide groups sixteen faces by what they signal.

Category	What it signals	Typefaces
Modernist Workhorses	Neutral and precise	Helvetica, Futura, DIN, Univers
Humanist & Contemporary	Approachable and warm	Avenir, Söhne, Gill Sans, Circular
Editorial & Stylistic	Tuned to a specific design thesis	Neue Montreal, GT Alpina, Monolisk, Didot / Playfair Display, Minion Pro
Functional & Display	Built for drafting and scale	Century Gothic / DIN Pro, Tungsten, Roboto / Montserrat

Choose by what your project argues.

CATEGORIES 1 AND 2

Modernist and Humanist Faces

Neutral and precise, then approachable and warm.

Typeface	Category	Best for	Free alternative
Helvetica	Modernist	Technical documentation, signage, resumes	Mac built-in; Arial on Windows
Futura	Modernist	Headers, competition boards, titles	Jost
DIN	Modernist	Annotating diagrams, design briefs	DM Sans
Univers	Modernist	Complex layouts, long-form text	Inter
Avenir	Humanist	Personal statements, project descriptions	Nunito
Söhne	Humanist	Modern branding	Space Grotesk
Gill Sans	Humanist	Storytelling, narrative	Lato
Circular	Humanist	Modern studio branding	Plus Jakarta Sans

CATEGORIES 3 AND 4

Editorial and Functional Faces

Tuned to a design thesis, then built for drafting and scale.

Typeface	Category	Best for	Free alternative
Neue Montreal	Editorial	High-end branding, editorial-style portfolios	Montserrat
GT Alpina	Editorial	Academic and research-based portfolios	Source Serif 4
Monolisk	Editorial	Brutalist projects	Archivo Black
Didot / Playfair	Editorial	Classical architecture, luxury	Playfair Display
Minion Pro	Editorial	Academic writing, text-heavy work	Crimson Pro
Century Gothic / DIN Pro	Functional	CAD and BIM environments	Poppins
Tungsten	Functional	Large-format displays	Oswald
Roboto / Montserrat	Functional	Digital portfolios, online decks	Roboto (free)

CONCEPT

Serif or Sans?

Neither is correct. The content and the medium decide.

Serif	Sans-serif
• **Minion Pro:** formal project statements, thesis documentation, classical analysis • **Garamond:** body text and detailed technical description, academic portfolios • **Bodoni:** project titles and high-contrast layouts	• **Helvetica:** body text, captions, annotations, digital portfolios • **Futura:** section headers, conceptual portfolios, minimalist layouts • **Montserrat:** digital presentations and contemporary projects

Rule of thumb: screen reading favors the clarity of a sans-serif. Print gives a serif room for subtlety and detail.

CONCEPT

Three Tests Before You Commit

Run every candidate through these before it goes in a style.

1

Assess the content

Traditional, academic work suits a serif. Contemporary, digital-focused work suits a sans-serif. Ask what the project argues.

2

Test the context

What works for a caption can fail in a project statement. Test with your own text, never placeholder text.

3

Consider the medium

Screen reading favors sans-serif clarity. Print allows more serif subtlety and detail. Most portfolios are read as PDFs on screen.

PAIRING

Pairing Principles

One family for headings, one for reading.

Two families, three at most

Mixing several serif families or several display faces signals indecision, not range.

Vary inside the family

Use weight, italic, and light before you add a new typeface. A single family in two weights is a valid pairing.

Contrast on purpose

A serif with a sans-serif, or two clearly different weights. Two faces that are almost alike look like a mistake.

Readability first

Keep decorative faces off body text. Clarity beats expression in a professional portfolio.

PAIRING

Four Pairings to Start From

From the Typeface Guide. Each has a free route if you do not have the commercial faces.

Pairing	Character	Free route	Good for
Futura + Minion Pro	Geometric headings, humanist serif body	Jost + Crimson Pro	Modernist work with a written argument
Helvetica + GT Alpina	Neutral system with editorial warmth	Helvetica (Mac) + Source Serif 4	Drawing-heavy, research-minded
DIN + Source Serif 4	Industrial precision, readable body text	DM Sans + Source Serif 4	Technical and structural projects
Söhne + Crimson Pro	Contemporary headings, classic body	Space Grotesk + Crimson Pro	Studio or branding-forward portfolios

Pairings and free routes come from the Typeface Guide. The Good for column is a suggestion.

HIERARCHY

Size Hierarchy

Shown at the sizes you will use. If title and body look alike at arm's length, the contrast is too weak.

Flexible Framework

National Building Arts Center, St. Louis, Missouri

The proposal introduces a modular timber structure that functions as a stable framework for diverse and shifting needs. Long spans, concrete, heavy timber, and ceramics reference the city's industrial architecture.

Fig. 3 Axonometric of the timber frame with attachable gantry, shelving, and curtain components.

Titles step down in size and weight to body to caption. Each level is distinct.

Display titles
24 to 48 pt

Subtitles and section headers
14 to 20 pt

Body text
9 to 11 pt

Captions
7 to 8 pt

Sample text: Flexible Framework statement from the Typeface Guide (WashU St. Louis, Spring 2021).

HIERARCHY

Where the Pairing Lives

Your four Session 04 paragraph styles are the home for the pairing.

Style	Used for	Typeface slot	Size range
Title	Project titles, splash pages	Heading face	24 to 48 pt
Subtitle	Running headers, accent lines	Heading face	14 to 20 pt
Body Text	Descriptions, long captions	Body face	9 to 11 pt (10/12 locks to the grid)
Caption	Credits and labels	Body face, italic or regular	7 to 8 pt

Edit the four styles, then apply them. In Body Text, set Align to Grid to All Lines (Indents and Spacing). Hand-formatting a single text frame is how two spreads end up with different titles.

TEXT

Setting the Text

Choosing the face is half the job. These four settings decide how a page of it reads.

Line length

Aim for 45 to 75 characters a line, Bringhurst's range for single-column text. One grid column is too narrow for body text.

EXAMPLE: 10 PT BODY TEXT ON THE COURSE GRID

One column (78 pt): about 15 characters. Three columns (258 pt): about 50. Four columns (348 pt): about 70.

Alignment

Set body text flush left, ragged right. Justified text in a narrow column opens uneven gaps between words.

FLUSH LEFT, RAGGED RIGHT

The proposal introduces a modular timber structure that functions as a stable framework for diverse needs.

JUSTIFIED

The proposal introduces a modular timber structure that functions as a stable framework for diverse needs.

Hyphenation

Turn hyphenation off in Title, Subtitle, and Caption. In Body Text, allow it only while the right edge stays clean.

HYPHENATION ON

Cranes, shelv-
ing, and curtains
hang from the frame.

HYPHENATION OFF

Cranes, shelving,
and curtains hang
from the frame.

Tracking on labels

Add a little tracking to small all-caps labels, such as section markers and running heads. Leave lowercase body text at the default.

DEFAULT

SECTION 02 · PROJECT ONE

WITH TRACKING

SECTION 02 · PROJECT ONE

EXAMPLE

Type Next to Drawings

Case Study 02, spread 2: the type stays small and sits against what it describes.



- **Captions:** small and italic, set directly against the rendering and the plan they describe.
- **Running footer:** page number, name, and project title in the same place on every spread.
- **One family:** the page reads as a single serif family, and the drawings stay the loudest thing on it.

Source: Case Study 02 on this site, spread 2.

EXAMPLE

A Title Page, Four Levels

Case Study 02, spread 6: weight and italic build the hierarchy, not a second typeface.



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Flexible Framework

National Building Arts Center
St. Louis, Missouri

The National Building Art Center, as it currently stands, is an archive for architectural and building trades artifacts and literature that have been acquired throughout the United States. Many of the artifacts within the collection originate from the city of St. Louis and relate to the city's industrial past. A past that made heavy use of masonry and cast iron techniques that are beginning to fade in modern construction. Flexible Framework is a building arts center that contains exhibition, archive, education, and maker space that serves the National Building Arts Center of St. Louis, Missouri.

Tasked with housing the diverse programmatic requirements of the Building Arts Center, the design of the new structure is composed of a timber framework capable of hosting a multitude of functions. The stable, structural framework acts as a matrix upon which elements can be attached to; gantry cranes, curtains, shelving systems, displays, operable doors, and more are able to fit within the framework and be applied in specific ways to address specific needs. Long spans, operability, concrete, heavy timber, and ceramics–spatial and material strategies that relate to St. Louis's industrial architecture–are employed in unique ways that are both cognizant of the industry that created St. Louis and anticipant of a new age of production.

Professor: Kelley Van Dyck Murphy
Washington University in St. Louis
Spring 2021

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- **Title:** bold and largest, at the top of the text block.
- **Subtitle:** italic and smaller, two lines of location.
- **Body:** roman, small, in a single block.
- **Credits:** italic again, set apart at the bottom of the block.

Source: Case Study 02 on this site, spread 6.

RESOURCES

Getting the Fonts

Check Adobe first, then Google Fonts, and only then a foundry.

Adobe Fonts

fonts.adobe.com

- Minion Pro and Futura PT are included with Creative Cloud. Adobe added Helvetica in 2025 (check the app for the version).
- Activate them at no extra cost.
- Adobe offers 40 to 60% student discounts on Creative Cloud.

Google Fonts

fonts.google.com

- Every free alternative in the guide lives here.
- Free for academic and professional work.
- Install the downloaded files, then restart InDesign.

Commercial foundries

myfonts.com

- Klim (Söhne), Grilli Type (GT Alpina), Pangram Pangram (Neue Montreal, Monolisk), Monotype and MyFonts (DIN Next, Univers, Gill Sans, Avenir Next).
- Many offer 50 to 90% educational discounts. Ask.

RESOURCES

Free Alternatives, Side by Side

Close in proportion, x-height, and character. All on Google Fonts unless noted.

Replaces	Free font
Helvetica	Mac built-in; Arial on Windows
Futura	Jost
DIN	DM Sans
Univers	Inter
Avenir	Nunito
Söhne	Space Grotesk
Gill Sans	Lato
Circular	Plus Jakarta Sans

Replaces	Free font
Neue Montreal	Montserrat
GT Alpina	Source Serif 4
Monolisk	Archivo Black
Didot	Playfair Display
Minion Pro	Crimson Pro
Century Gothic	Poppins
Tungsten	Oswald
Roboto	Roboto (same font)

Source: Architecture Portfolio Typeface Guide, pages 24 and 26.

CONCEPT

Common Mistakes, Quick Fixes

Too many families

Cut to two, three at most. Use weight and italic for variety.

A decorative face on body text

Keep display faces to titles. Body needs a reading face.

Choosing from a specimen page

Set your own paragraph in it first. Test with your own text.

Type competing with the drawings

Drawing-heavy spreads usually want a quiet, neutral face.

Sizes that drift between spreads

Apply paragraph styles. Do not hand-format.

Captions below 7 pt

Stay in the 7 to 8 pt range and check at 100% on screen.